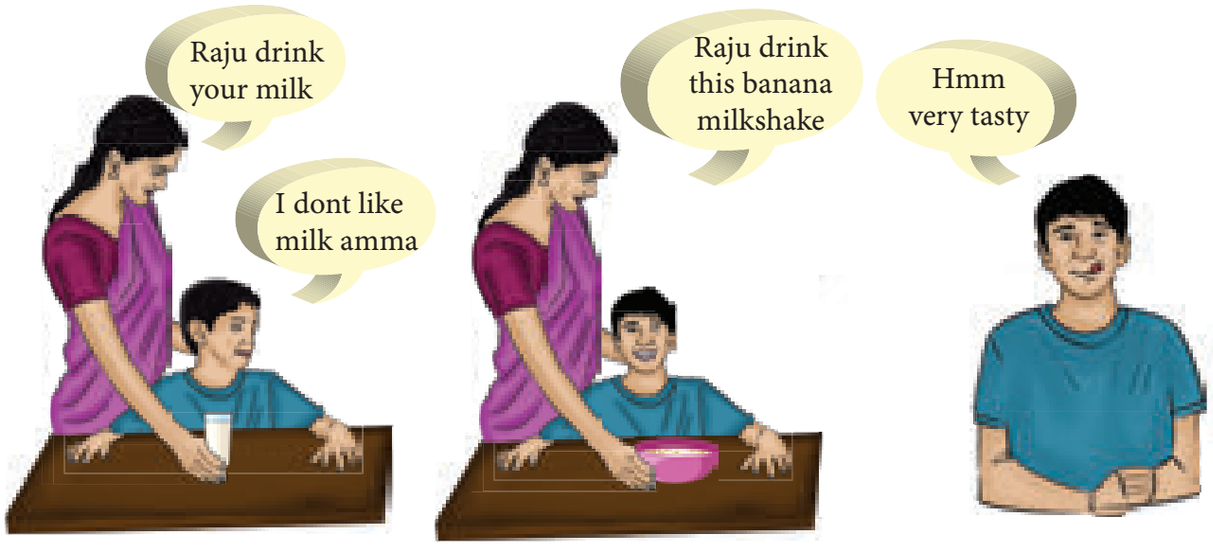


The form in which food is served influences food acceptance

c. Food habits and religious beliefs

Religious and socio-cultural beliefs influence the choice of food. Certain foods are prohibited by certain religions. Also, the socio-cultural factors either promote or prohibit the intake of particular foods indifferent families and communities.

d. Food availability and seasonal variation

As far as possible, seasonal and locally available foods should be used. Vegetables and fruits in season are not only cheap but have the highest nutrient content and best flavour.

e. Food Fads

Wrong notions and beliefs regarding consumption of food are prevalent in different communities many of which are baseless and may deprive an important nutrient source. For example, fad-like milk and fish should not be included in the same meal. These food fads need to be discouraged.

f. Portion sizes

While planning and preparing a meal, it must be ensured that the quantity prepared be easily consumed by the person of the given age, sex and activity. At the same time, the quantity must meet nutritional needs. These quantities are referred to as "one serving portion" or "portion sizes".

1.4 Steps in meal planning

The following steps may be adopted in planning meals.

1. Recommended Dietary Allowances

To plan a balanced diet the first step is to know the recommended dietary allowances for different age groups.

2. Food list

The next step is to prepare a food list ie., a list of quantities of various food groups to be included in the diet so that it is balanced and can meet the RDA. This can be done by

- Selecting foods from all the five food groups.
- Deciding the quantities of the selected foods as multiples of portion sizes.

The number of portion of various food groups to be included in planning a balanced diet for adults is given in Table- 1.2

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